

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

DAN DOBOS

2

The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.

What Do the Leaning Tower of Pisa, Improvised Jazz, and Japanese Pottery Have in Common?

The Leaning Tower of Pisa was created by accident. A mistake made during its construction in 1173 caused the tower to tilt. In fact, the defective structural design had to be stabilized from a 5.5-degree tilt to a 3.97-degree tilt in the 1990s for safety reasons. Yet this unintentional defect has become one of its most celebrated features, drawing visitors from around the world. The defect created the beauty.

When musicians play improvised jazz, by definition, they do not follow the notes on the score. We delight in the new melodies formed by the deviation from the planned composition.

Imagine a shattered teacup, not discarded, but painstakingly pieced back together, the cracks filled with shimmering gold. This is *kintsugi*, a practice in Japanese pottery that sees beauty in imperfections. Instead of hiding the flaws, they are accentuated, creating a unique and beautiful piece of art.

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

The Leaning Tower of Pisa, improvised jazz, and the Japanese art of *kintsugi* highlight how there is beauty in the unexpected, the irregular, the interruption of the pattern. You are no different. Your specific challenges are a high-definition image of your authenticity. No one else has experienced your difficulties with the level of detail and clarity that you have. Your challenges contain seeds of brilliance that you can use to create distinctive work.

The challenging experiences that leave you feeling shattered are not meant to be hidden. Just as the *kintsugi* artisan carefully restores each crack, you too can pick up the fragments of your past and begin the process of golden repair.

Just as a jazz musician is valued for their unique melodies, you too will find success by tackling issues connected to your personal struggles. The first step is to recognize that you are not your work.



Figure 2: The practice of kintsugi accentuates flaws by filling them with gold.
View and download this photo in full color at:
ChooseYourWorkBook.com/kintsugi

You Are Not Your Work

The most common reaction that people have when they think back to emotionally challenging experiences is, “Oh, I just wasn’t good enough.”

That’s very different from writing an article and wondering, “Is this a high-quality article?” This is a great question to ask because it will help you identify the criteria for high-quality work. By knowing these criteria, you will write a better article.

Observe the difference between “Is this a high-quality article?” and “Am I a good writer?” When you ask the latter question, you might hesitate and lower your self-worth. This leads to a feeling of despair. Instead of facing challenges and giving them your best shot, you get swept up in a mixture of overthinking and insecurity.

So how do we separate the two? Challenge the quality of your work, but never challenge your self-worth. At your core, you are whole. Nothing can diminish your inherent value.

You can further improve the quality of your work by changing “Is this a high-quality article?” to “What could make this article better?” This more specific approach avoids the heightened emotion connected to the vague “This is great” versus “This is terrible.” Your most perceptive insights emerge when you sit behind the article and contemplate both its strengths and weaknesses. Notice how this has everything to do with the article and nothing to do with you.

In the same way that you separate the quality of your work from the quality of yourself, it is equally important to distinguish between what happened in the past and who you are today. You are not your work. You are not your profession. You are not the situations you have encountered. You are something far greater.

In light of this separation, let’s now examine what happens if you fail to confront your past challenges.

The Problem with Ignoring a Challenging Experience

When I was working in the corporate world, I was emotionally disconnected from my work. My initial discomfort wasn't a sharp pain that was strong enough to compel change. Instead, it was more like a dull, recurring ache, the kind that lingers in the background and slowly wears you down. A persistent gray fog, absent of both joy and sadness, settled over my daily lukewarm mediocrity.

Some people suffer their entire lives with this familiar discomfort to the point that they stop noticing it. I eventually realized that when I numbed myself to one feeling, I actually numbed myself to all feelings. By failing to engage with my emotions, I was trapped in a maze of indecision, constantly second-guessing my choices and desires.

When you ignore your feelings, you are more likely to get stuck in unsatisfying work. The only thing worse than doing unsatisfying work is pretending that it's not a problem.

When you notice pain, feel the pain. When you notice joy, feel the joy.

Think back to a time in your past that was both emotionally intense and difficult to navigate. Pause to recall the specific sensations that you remember experiencing. Only by fully feeling the moment can you comprehend its larger significance.

Here is a series of comparisons by psychologist Steven C. Hayes to help you feel an experience more fully. For each comparison, pause long enough to connect it to a challenging experience.

Hold your experience like a delicate flower in your hand.

Embrace your experience like a crying child.

Sit with your experience like you would sit with a person with a serious illness.

Look at your experience like you would look at an incredible painting.

Walk with your experience like you'd walk while carrying a sobbing infant.

THE UNEXPECTED GIFTS HIDDEN IN YOUR STRUGGLES

Honor your experience like you'd honor a friend by listening carefully even if it was hard.

Inhale your experience the way you would take a deep breath.

Abandon the fight like a soldier putting down the weapon and walking home.

Take in your experience like a glass of pure cold water.

Carry your experience like a picture in your wallet.

In business, I've faced several setbacks. These comparisons have been invaluable in helping me to peacefully reconnect with a challenging experience, reframe it, and gain clarity. They have helped me realize that compassion is not just important for the sake of being kind to others. We are all grappling with our own internal struggles. By recognizing that most people are doing the best they can with what they have, compassion helps you to see more clearly.

Now that you have felt your challenging experience more fully, the next step is to let it go.

The Rock Concert

We're now going to transform your challenging experience into something new by doing an activity together.

Take a moment to revisit the experience and concentrate on a specific feeling it evokes. It could be anxiety — the tension or unease from a perceived threat. Maybe it's sadness — a heaviness or sorrow weighing on your mind. You might feel anger — a sense of resentment or irritation toward a situation or a certain person. Perhaps it's guilt — the feeling of responsibility for something that went wrong. Or maybe it's disappointment — the letdown when expectations are not met. Whichever emotion you notice, allow yourself to feel it fully for ten seconds.

Imagine you're standing in front of the stage at a rock concert, close enough to touch the performers. You don't just hear the music; you feel it reverberating through every bone in your body. The pounding bass

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

echoes in your chest as the scent of smoke and sweat mingles in the air around you. Strobe lights flash intensely, painting the crowd in rapid, fleeting bursts of color.

This rock concert is a metaphor for your challenging experience — intense, overwhelming, and transformative. Don't engage with any words or thoughts. Just surrender to the raw sensation of the moment, letting it wash over you and carry you away on a tide of pure emotion.

Now imagine you're in a helicopter above the concert. With binoculars, you zoom in and see yourself immersed deeply in the rock concert, immersed in that painful experience. But when you take away the binoculars, you see everyone else at the concert. You can see the band, the lights, and thousands of people. You become a witness to the experience. Instead of being swept up by the emotion, you sit back in your seat and relax behind it, looking at the scene from a distance.

You stay with it. You don't comment. You simply observe it. You see it in its entirety, and then... you let it go. The helicopter departs from the scene. You look back toward the concert as it gets smaller and smaller and then disappears.

You are no longer there. The concert is now in the past. You are here in the present. It's a prior experience. It's not you. And as you let it go:

- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...

And you notice that you now feel a little bit lighter.

Look at the fragments of your experience. Were they broken, chipped, shattered? Take a breath. Imagine you're a *kintsugi* master, picking up the

pieces of this experience. As you allow gold to flow through the cracks, what was once pain is now transformed into beauty.

The experience is still part of you, but it no longer defines you. It transforms into something beautiful and strong that will guide you in the next stage of your journey. The transformation not only enriches your life, but by letting go of the past, you are able to make space for the future. With a lighter load, you are much better positioned to discover the work that you are meant to do.

Who Am I Now?

Too often we criticize our prior actions — even those from several years ago — to the point that we let them distort our present experience. Yet the cells in our bodies are replaced daily. In about ninety days, most of your roughly 30 trillion cells will transform into new ones. You are not only a more mature and experienced person with evolved thinking patterns; you are also a biologically different person from who you were several years ago.

If you were exactly the same person you were many years ago, you might be angry with yourself because you may repeat the same behavior. But you are a different person now. Even if you wanted to, replicating the past would be almost impossible. Yes, breathe a huge sigh of relief because the past is over and done with. You will still face challenges, and even if elements of the past repeat, knowing the future will differ from the past should bring you some joy. As your capacity to respond grows, you will have new, richer, and more interesting experiences than ever before.

After even a mildly intense experience, it can be interesting to ponder: Who am I now? How have I evolved? The answer: it's a mystery. You never quite know exactly who you are. All that you can be sure of is that you have grown. Maturity is about accepting the flux of life and recognizing that failure is baked into the process of growth.

How Your Challenges Help You Grow

Rabbi Harold Kushner reflected on the death of his son, who tragically passed away from a rare genetic disease at just fourteen years old. He said:

I'm a more sensitive person, a more effective pastor, a more sympathetic counselor because of Aaron's life and death than I would've been without it. And I would give up all those gains in a second if I could have my son back. If I could choose, I would forego all of the spiritual growth and depth, which has come my way because of our experience. But I cannot choose.

He not only accepted what happened, but he learned from it, grew from it, and moved forward. That's what we want to do now. We must take this difficult experience and move beyond acceptance. We must use it as a springboard to grow.

Viktor Frankl, an Austrian psychiatrist, personifies such growth. While trapped in the atrocities of a concentration camp, he articulated a profound truth with exceptional clarity:

We who lived in concentration camps can remember the men who walked through the huts comforting others, giving away their last piece of bread. They may have been few in number, but they offer sufficient proof that everything can be taken from a person but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way.

To help survive these atrocious conditions, Frankl wrote notes about his work and hid them in his coat. He was dedicated to his craft for his entire lifetime. He knew what he stood for. For Frankl, psychiatry wasn't merely a profession. It was a calling. He knew that he was sent to do this work. So he did it, and he did it exceptionally well. Indeed, after being freed from the concentration camp, Frankl wrote his groundbreaking book *Man's Search for Meaning* in just nine days.

Sixty-nine years after Viktor Frankl wrote his book, Anthony Ray Hinton was released from prison in another part of the world. After

being framed by the police, Hinton was wrongfully imprisoned for a full thirty years, spending almost his entire time on death row. His Alabama prison cell was infested with rats and cockroaches. He was given scarcely enough food to survive. He spent barely fifteen minutes a day out of his cell. He heard the shrieks of other cellmates being executed in the electric chair. Then the odor of death filled the air, leaving a grim reminder of the execution that occurred just meters away.

How would you respond to these living conditions? While most would lose their composure, Hinton responded with a level of character that we can only hope to emulate, an inimitable ability to transcend the horrific conditions he endured and the gross injustice so mercilessly inflicted upon him. Recounting his experiences, this great man echoed the wisdom of Viktor Frankl, stating:

Despair was a choice. Hatred was a choice. Anger was a choice. I still had choices and that knowledge rocked me... I could choose to give up or to hang on. Hope was a choice. Faith was a choice. And more than anything, love was a choice.

While falsely imprisoned, Hinton established a book club for fellow inmates. After his release, instead of retreating into a private life, Hinton did the opposite. He devoted himself to public speaking, offering hope to those confronted by injustice. His quiet strength and powerful message resonated globally as he harnessed the transformative power of suffering to uplift the lives of others. Hinton's lost years behind bars fueled his public speaking with an intense energy that deeply impacted the lives of those who heard him speak.

Kushner, Frankl, and Hinton each accomplished something very rare. They mastered the art of emotional judo. Judo is the art of using your opponent's weight to redirect their force instead of confronting it head-on. Similarly, emotional judo harnesses negative emotions so that, instead of letting them weaken you, their weight elevates you to a higher level of consciousness. These men transcended their situations by choosing hope over despair, offering us a profound example of how to live.

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

These experiences highlight that while there will always be challenges, the inescapable question is: Are you willing to use the force of these difficulties to create a transformation? These experiences are valuable because they give you depth, mold your character, and improve the quality of your thinking. As Camus put it, “In the depths of winter, I finally learned that within me there lay an invincible summer.”

These men also teach us how struggles can become the driving force behind work that is personally fulfilling and valuable to others. Just as Frankl further excelled in psychology and Hinton devoted himself to advocating for justice, you too can establish a new path illuminated by your challenging experiences.

Hopefully, you haven’t endured a fraction of the atrocities faced by Kushner, Frankl, or Hinton. However, if you hadn’t struggled at all, you wouldn’t appreciate the contrast between your past and present. More importantly, you can use these past struggles as seeds to cultivate something beautiful. The pain loses its sting when you absorb its lesson.

This is just the first stage of your journey. Your past challenges are here to help you navigate the next stage.

As the Zen proverb states, *Who knows what is good or bad luck?* It is easy to fall into the trap of believing that getting what you want will create the best experience for you. But more often, it is in the thick of challenging experiences that you uncover hidden gems. It is in these experiences that you break barriers, change perceptions, and create memories that leave an indelible mark on your life.

How to Channel Your Emotions to Build Something Remarkable

When John Wilson was twelve years old, his chemistry class participated in a routine experiment involving boiling water. Unfortunately, a lab assistant had mislabeled a bottle, so instead of boiling water, John boiled a much more reactive substance. The substance caused the container to

explode, shattering many glass bottles. Tragically, John Wilson left that science experiment completely blind.

Most people would be devastated, sink into depression, and lose hope. But John just got on with it. He quickly learned to read Braille, became an accomplished rower, swimmer, and actor, and studied law at Oxford University.

At age twenty-seven, he found himself in Africa. He noticed that blindness was far more prevalent there than in the Western world due to a lack of medical resources. He reflected on how his blindness resulted from an accident and grew angry that millions of others were blind simply due to insufficient resources. Something had to be done, so John established several organizations that helped prevent blindness in tens of millions of people.

If Sir John Wilson could turn his deeply unfortunate experience into a project that helped millions of people, what might be buried in your challenging experience, waiting to be uncovered? Observe the mixture of anger, frustration, and compassion that John felt and how he channeled that energy into something useful. Now, tap into the emotions that your challenges elicit. Feel the emotion deeply. Just as the *kintsugi* artist fills the cracks with gold, use the energy that comes from your challenges to create something that matters to you. Choose the work that fills the cracks with gold.

The Value of Writing About Challenges

When you write about your challenges, you release ideas that were taxing your mind. You expel negative emotions from your body. What once burdened your mind and strained your body now exists in its own place, on its own sheet of paper, separate from you. Now that you are no longer gripped by this narrow emotional focus, you can broaden your gaze and consider related thoughts. This is how you develop perspective.

The more you write, the more your writing reveals to you that you are not your thoughts. You are not your experiences. Your thoughts and

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

experiences are separate from you because you are something far greater. You grow to discover that emotions stemming from difficult experiences have a perverse allure, leading you to replay them over and over in your head. But when you write about the experience and let it go, you uncover its hidden value as you progress to the next stage of your growth.

The Hidden Gift

Reflecting on the challenging experience visualized in this chapter:

1. What is the strongest emotion that surfaces when I think about my challenging experience? (e.g., fear, gratitude, relief, frustration)
2. As I sit with this emotion, what emerges as truly important? What have I learned about myself from this experience, and how have I grown from it?
3. Based on what I have learned, what is a project that I would love to pursue?

Duration

Two minutes per question

Feel free to extend this reflection if you're finding it valuable. Writing about challenges can be emotional, so be gentle with yourself. Through this reflection, you're beginning the process of transforming your challenges into sources of strength and insight.

Like the *kintsugi* master carefully mending cracks with gold, you're finding beauty and clarity in your struggles. Let this new perspective guide your choice of work. Perhaps a past experience revealed a hidden strength or highlighted a problem you're now driven to solve. Connect the dots between past and present to envision a project that feels less like a job and more like a calling.

Since this activity is more emotional than others, many find that writing by hand is the best way to complete it.

-

-

8

How to Overcome the Curse of Competence

Why traditional education may undervalue your greatest strength and what to do about it.

Do You Have a Learning Disorder?

Sir Ken Robinson was a British author, speaker, and international advisor on education, renowned for his TED Talk “Do Schools Kill Creativity?”, which has been viewed over 100 million times. Separately, he has shared a story about a girl named Gillian who was eight years old when her school wrote to her parents complaining about her poor academic performance and disruptive classroom behavior. They said she had a high-risk future and suggested she might have a learning disorder requiring her to attend a different school. This worried her parents, so they spoke to a psychologist.

During the consultation, Gillian felt uneasy, knowing the psychologist’s evaluation could significantly impact her future. At one point, the psychologist left Gillian alone in a room with the radio on. Gillian danced around the room, displaying incredible grace and immense skill. It was clear she was a gifted dancer. After just a few minutes of being transfixed by this dancing, the psychologist turned to Gillian’s mother and said to

her, “Your daughter doesn’t have a learning disorder. She’s a dancer. Take her to a dance school.”

That’s exactly what Gillian’s mother did. Gillian auditioned for the Royal Ballet School in London, and to her delight, they accepted her. She discovered a whole group of people who, in her own words, “had to move to think.” Gillian then went on to form her own musical production company. She collaborated with Andrew Lloyd Webber and created performances that brought joy to countless audiences around the world. Gillian Lynne, the eight-year-old with a high-risk future, became one of the most successful choreographers ever. She performed for millions, made millions of dollars, and lived a fulfilling life until her death at the remarkable age of ninety-two.

Now, imagine if Gillian hadn’t visited a psychologist who recognized that her academic struggles did not make her broken, but simply made her different. Imagine if her mother had simply said, “Oh well, the school must be right. We’ll send her to a different school.” Imagine if Gillian were told nothing more than to calm down and stop causing trouble. Gillian was lucky she met an insightful psychologist who guided her in the right direction. This chapter is your opportunity to have a similar encounter.

Gillian’s story highlights that when we are emotionally engaged in our work, our ability to learn and improve is exponentially higher than when we dread what we do. Gillian’s success exposes the fallacy that intelligence is a function of mental horsepower, a misconception created by the Industrial Revolution’s narrow fixation on literacy and numeracy. Indeed, psychologist Howard Gardner’s Theory of Multiple Intelligences shows that aside from linguistic intelligence (thinking in words and language) and logical-mathematical intelligence (dealing with numbers), there are six additional intelligences that receive far less attention.

1. **How does a sculptor visualize a finished piece before carving the stone?** The sculptor uses *spatial intelligence*, much like sailors visualize their position in the ocean and navigate by the stars. The ability to think in three dimensions is used by sailors, pilots, sculptors, painters, and architects.

2. **How does a surgeon perform delicate operations with precise hand movements and hand-eye coordination?** Surgeons use *kinesthetic intelligence*, much like dancers such as Gillian Lynne, who express themselves through their bodies' movements. The ability to control bodily movements and manipulate the movement of objects is used by athletes, dancers, surgeons, and artists.
3. **How did Ludwig van Beethoven create symphonies that are still celebrated today, despite being almost completely deaf?** Beethoven used *musical intelligence*, much like composers, conductors, and musicians, who discern pitch, rhythm, timbre, and tone.
4. **How does a teacher create a more engaging learning environment?** Teachers use *interpersonal intelligence*, much like actors and leaders, to engage deeply with others.
5. **How did Nelson Mandela maintain his self-awareness, inner strength, and commitment to reconciliation despite spending twenty-seven years in prison?** Mandela used *intrapersonal intelligence*, much like writers, psychologists, and mindfulness teachers, who are in touch with their feelings, fears, and motivations.
6. **How did Charles Darwin develop the Theory of Evolution?** Darwin used *naturalistic intelligence*, much like biologists, veterinarians, and wildlife managers, who appreciate and understand the natural world.

Whoever suggested that Gillian had a learning disorder needed to spend more time learning about the definition of intelligence. Are the most academically qualified professors at the most elite colleges also elite athletes? If not, do they have a kinesthetic learning disorder? Or do they just play to their strengths and ignore their weaknesses?

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

Shaped by the demands of the Industrial Revolution, the traditional education system has long prioritized literacy and numeracy over other types of intelligence. This bias is structural, not a failure of the many teachers who strive daily to nurture their students' diverse gifts. Yet beyond the classroom, the world applauds those who lean into their unique strengths — dancers, athletes, inventors, creators, and many more — proving that brilliance comes in many forms.

Let's now explore which of these intelligences is your greatest strength.

What Is the True Definition of a Strength?

We're told our strengths are the things we're good at, while our weaknesses are the things we're not good at. Seems obvious, right? Well, it turns out to be wrong. It's not how good you are at an activity that matters. It's how the activity makes you feel. A strength makes you feel stronger. It's an expression of your true self. A weakness makes you feel weaker.

You might be a skilled accountant, but if crunching numbers drains your energy and leaves you feeling depleted, it's a weakness, not a strength. On the other hand, if public speaking energizes and invigorates you, even if you're not the most polished speaker, it's a strength worth pursuing and developing into a valuable skill that could transform your career.

When you engage a weakness, you betray your true self. You're doing something you know you are not meant to be doing. The result is that even if you achieve a positive outcome, it feels flat and meaningless. The whole process robs you of energy.

Of course, sometimes you need to use a weakness to move a project forward. But don't mistake this for your path. Choosing your work is less about becoming well-rounded and more about becoming well-directed.

The key question to ask here is, "How does this activity make me feel? Does this activity give me energy and make me feel stronger? Or does this activity drain my energy and make me feel weaker?"

As you gravitate toward activities that energize you, work no longer feels like strenuous effort you must endure. Instead, it is an inherently rewarding activity that feels exciting. Choose the work that gives you energy.

Why Do You Hesitate to Engage with Your Strengths?

When I studied law/engineering, I remember all too clearly being asked on the first day, “Why did you decide to study law?” and one student responded, “I chose law because I didn’t get into medicine.” He later mentioned that he just wanted to study something that looked impressive. If he couldn’t get into medicine, law was second best. Some parents say, “You can do anything you like with your life, provided it’s law, medicine, or engineering.” If only this were merely comedy and not the reality for many children.

You enter the world endowed with a specific gift to share. But then you are told to “keep your options open” and to choose a secure job at a well-established company. Elite performers, in contrast, focus on one thing, not multiple options. They choose the path that helps them grow the most, even if there is a risk that things won’t work out the first time.

Every time you trade growth for stability, you also enroll in boredom and tedium. Is that a good deal? Worse, you rob the world of the gifts you possess. Don’t shortchange humanity by sitting on the sidelines. Step up. The world cannot wait to hear the music that you have to share.

Psychologist Abraham Maslow has famously said, “A musician must make music, an artist must paint, a poet must write, if he is to be ultimately at peace with himself.” You might be someone different.

A photographer must capture moments.

A journalist must uncover the truth.

A mediator must foster common understanding.

What is it that you must do?

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

Know that you will not be at peace until you find the work that you came here to do. You are not here to pursue some abstract idea or to impress anyone or to waste your time. No, you were put on this planet to discover your strengths and share them with the world.

You were put on this planet to choose your work.

How grateful are you just for being born into this world? How grateful are you that you can participate in the miracle of consciousness? If you are truly grateful for this incomparable gift, then you are obligated to embrace your natural strengths to offer something of value to the world. If you are truly grateful, you cannot ignore the massive opportunity cost of squandering your time on activities that drain your energy.

So develop your craft. Work at it. Improve it. Reflect on it. Jazz saxophonist John Coltrane was known to practice a single note for ten hours straight to get the tone and volume exactly right. Many marvel at Stephen Curry's seemingly magical ability to shoot hoops, but few appreciate his relentless practice — 300 to 500 shots every single day, including weekends, amounting to roughly 1.9 million shots over fifteen years. Pablo Picasso created over 20,000 paintings, prints, drawings, sculptures, ceramics, and theater sets. Thomas Edison acquired 1,093 United States patents during his eighty-four-year lifetime, equivalent to one patent every two weeks during his working life. You cannot purchase mastery, nor can you rush it. You must put in the work.

But notice how Coltrane and Curry did not simply put in the work. They both also chose highly engaging work. Mixing hard work with your natural strengths creates a potent chemical reaction that makes you unstoppable.

Think about how this applies to you. If you're even mildly successful in a role that doesn't energize you, imagine the exponentially greater success you would experience by intensely focusing on work that invigorates you rather than depletes your energy.

You might decide to become world-class in an endeavor. But then doubt sets in and you hear yourself saying, "Who am I to reach a world-

class level?” On the other hand, you could ask yourself, “Why not?” Often, you doubt yourself because the world overvalues safety and is filled with a pervasive sense of negativity and cynicism. There is no reason you have to engage with this negativity.

There are countless examples of individuals who refused to accept the cynicism around them. For example, standing at just five feet three inches tall, Muggsy Bogues did not appear to be an elite basketball player. But despite his height disadvantage, he had an incredibly successful career spanning over a decade as the shortest player to ever compete in the NBA. Oprah Winfrey was born into poverty in rural Mississippi to a teenage single mother, and she has since gone on to create a billion-dollar media empire. Statistically, Oprah Winfrey and Muggsy Bogues were never meant to be successful. But their work provided them with vast amounts of energy. What are the activities that bring you vast amounts of energy?

The Curse of Competence

- 1. What are three specific activities I do at work that I am good at but don't particularly enjoy?*
- 2. What are three actions I can take to limit my time doing these activities? How can I automate them, delegate them, or eliminate their less important parts?*
- 3. If I could only take one action to limit my time doing these activities, what would it be?*

Duration

Three minutes

By setting boundaries around draining tasks, you create space for work that truly lights you up.

Write a list of these activities. Beside each activity, consider how you can delegate, minimize, or eliminate each item.

Feel free to go over the suggested duration. This reflection is short by design because small, consistent shifts create lasting changes.

Write Your Reflections Here

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

- ☐ I have identified some things that I am good at but don't particularly enjoy.
- ☐ I have identified at least three actions to limit my time doing these activities.

In the Next Chapter...

When you choose the work that gives you energy, you choose your work. Equally, you want to engage in work that you find meaningful. That's what we will discuss next.

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

Contents

	The Key to Making This Book Work for You	xiii
	This is not a book to simply read.	
1	What If My Whole Life Has Been Wrong?	1
	Why do so many people experience a deep sense of regret at the end of their lives?	
	<i>Pause: The Three-Year Mirror</i>	
2	The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles	17
	How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.	
	<i>Pause: The Hidden Gift</i>	
3	Don't Confuse Success with Suffering in Comfort	33
	Why your focus on comfort is ruining your life and obscuring the true metrics of success.	
	<i>Pause: The Comfort Trap</i>	
4	How Do You Pay the Bills and Still Choose Your Work?	49
	The one hour that changes everything.	
	<i>Pause: The Hour of Possibility</i>	
5	How to Think Independently in a World Obsessed with Conformity	63
	Why does conforming to the herd hamper your personal growth?	
	<i>Pause: The Hidden Voice</i>	
6	Rational Work Only Produces Rational Results	79
	The unexpected path to extraordinary achievement.	
	<i>Pause: The Rational Trap</i>	
7	Let the Work Choose You	91
	How to tap into your intuition to reach the next level of growth.	
	<i>Pause: The Intuitive Path</i>	
8	How to Overcome the Curse of Competence	105
	Why traditional education may undervalue your greatest strength and what to do about it.	
	<i>Pause: The Curse of Competence</i>	

9	You Don't Really Want to Lie on the Beach All Day	115
	What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?	
	<i>Pause: The Cathedral</i>	
10	Next Steps to a Fulfilling Life	131
	How to capitalize on this pivotal moment.	
	<i>Pause: The One Project</i>	
	Appendices	
1	Action Plan	141
	A roadmap to convert your insights into action.	
2	How Well-Meaning Parents Unknowingly Steer Their Children Away from Fulfilling Work	145
	Understanding the subtle yet powerful influence parents have on career choices.	
3	What Next?	149
	Stay connected and inspired on your path to fulfilling work.	
4	Frequently Asked Questions	151
	Answers to the most common questions about choosing your work.	
5	The Ten Most Important Questions to Help You Choose Your Work	153
	Start with just one question each day.	
6	Financial Planning for Choosing Your Work	157
	Practical financial strategies to help you on your new path.	
7	Summary and Bonus Strategies	159
	A short guide to help you take action.	
	Notes	161
	Index	190

**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

•

Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat